detract from the skill with which Lal has documented Gulbadan Begum's life.

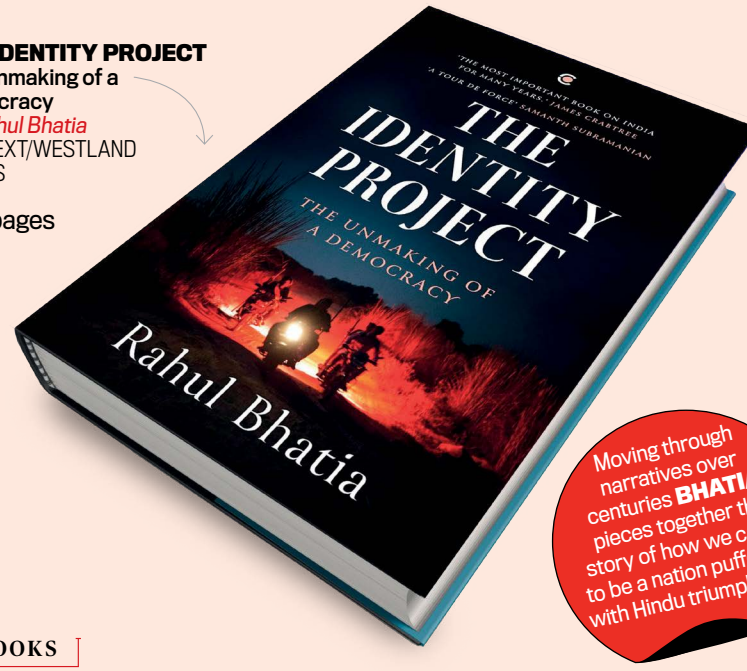
Babur: A Chessboard King is a different kind of book. Its introduction sets out its purpose as being to undo the harm done by the venerable NCERT history textbooks which "were a catastrophe set to dismantle the pride and respect of our land and civilisation". With this objective, the Mughals—or, more correctly, the Timurids—are chosen as a field of study to demonstrate how "intolerance was a part of their conduct" and the aim was a "hardcore Islamist" empire.

All this winds the reader up in anticipation of revelations only to be let down as the book is an anti-climax. In sum, it is a paraphrase of the *Baburnama* till about the end of the first decade of the 16th century, about 15 years before Babur's conquest of Hindustan. There is little here that substantiates the author's main claim that we have been brought up on a diet of mistruths about our medieval history.

That story will no doubt emerge in subsequent volumes. In the meantime, we have a section of the old *Baburnama* attempting to look different with some tedious and repetitive footnotes and endnotes. ■

–T.C.A. Raghavan

THE IDENTITY PROJECT
The Unmaking of a Democracy
By Rahul Bhatia
CONTEXT/WESTLAND BOOKS
₹**899**;
464 pages



Moving through narratives over centuries **BHATIA** pieces together the story of how we came to be a nation puffed up with Hindu triumphalism

BOOKS

THE CLOSING OF THE INDIAN MIND

The Identity Project by **Rahul Bhatia** is an incisive work of reportage

"What a beautiful country this is," says Nisar, a resident of northeastern Delhi and a victim of the 2020 Delhi riots, as he drives the journalist Rahul Bhatia (Nisar's police protection slumbering in the backseat), to his village in Uttar Pradesh. "It's such a big country and they've made it so small. They've filled people's heads with rumour and innuendo so they hate each other." Bhatia tells Nisar's story with assiduous care, following him as he seeks justice from a profoundly flawed Indian system, arguably hijacked by Hindu nationalists, in which he appears to have implicit faith. "But people don't read," Nisar tells Bhatia. "They don't read their own books and try to understand."

Some people do read. And what they read and how they interpret it warps their understanding. In the same section towards the end of *The Identity Project*, Bhatia's excellent work of reportage, a lawyer representing some Hindu men, affiliated with the Vishva Hindu Parishad, accused of being aggressors in the riots, asserts that the "evidence of every society is found in its books". The evidence he finds in his eclectic readings is that there is "nothing that has benefited mankind" that Hindus haven't known or discovered.

Moving adroitly between centuries, between the narratives of seers, technocrats, politicians and people whose lives have been upended by Hindutva, Bhatia pieces together the story of how we got where we are—citizens of Modi's India, a country puffed up with a Hindu triumphalism that longs to avenge centuries of humiliation by inflicting some humiliation of their own.

Speaking to Partha Banerjee, the author of *In the Belly of the Beast: The Hindu Supremacist RSS and the BJP of India: An Insider's Story*, Bhatia uncovers how the RSS "seduces through community and family, exerting a gravitational force on individuals". Banerjee, once an RSS officer himself, moved to the US to pursue graduate studies. Far from India, Banerjee came to understand, by 1995, that the "Hindu future he grew up hearing about from his father, in *shakhas* and in training camps, was suddenly here". As he tells Bhatia, "I felt they were materialising their long-term doctrine that India was for Hindus."

That project, shows Bhatia, is near its culmination. Can Indian democracy summon the strength and will to check the Hindu nationalist project? It will need the Opposition to present a newly imagined, freshly compelling alternative to the corrupt, complacent and now discredited secularism of the past. ■

–Shougat Dasgupta